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WEEK OF APRIL 22, 2009

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Earth Day Education



Photo by Doreen Sugierski

At last weekend's Earth Day celebration at the Florence Soule Library in Denver, Jaimie White of the Carolina Raptor Center tells how Dudley the Great Horned Owl was imprinted on humans from birth and never learned to hunt so he cannot live in the wild. More photos on page 30.

Rescue Squad failed to submit required audits last 15 yrs.

By Ken H. Fortenberry
It's been 15 years since the East Lincoln Rescue Squad provided the county with an annual audit of its finances - a requirement of its contract with the county.

Now that the squad is shutting down and giving away an estimated \$1.6 million in assets, attention is being focused on its finances and why it never submitted the required audits.

The squad is refusing to even answer the question if audits have been performed the past 15 years and, if so, when the last one was completed. The non-profit squad has been supported by tax dollars and community donations for nearly three decades.

Rescue squad assistant chief and spokesman Ross Bula said the board of directors has de-

cided not to answer any further questions from news@norman.

A copy of its 2007 IRS Form 990 is available online, and shows that the squad has more than \$220,000 in cash and savings, and nearly \$700,000 in other assets including vehicles and equipment.

Its building and land on North Highway 16 has a county tax value of \$722,907, but is not included on the listed value on the 990 form.

County Finance Director Leon Harmon confirmed that the last audit he received was in 1994.

"How sad is that? The county should have demanded better," said Alex Patton, chairman of the county commission since last December.

"No one in Lincoln County ever looked at a contract with
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It's time to spread a little kindness and to use our manners

Apparently we've become a nation of bad-mannered people. When I was growing up, manners and etiquette were taught in our home. People of my generation said "please" and "thank you." That was as natural as some people find cursing these days.

And we wonder why we are like we are. Isn't it refreshing to hear a child use good manners? Unfortunately, many of us have become nonchalant with how we treat others, how we expect to be treated and what is acceptable.

With people stressed out about everything these days, we all need to try to act a little nicer to each other. Manners go a long



Anna J. Fortenberry

way to make life better. Especially in difficult times, people need to be kind to one another. A kind word can go a long way.

I get a lot of column ideas from e-mails I receive. This one really caught my attention. There is a designated week for just about everything and now there is one called "Celebrate Etiquette Week" - a time set

aside for us all to be better mannered - May 11-15.

The concept is a good one... "stop the bad manners virus!" Calling it a virus is exactly correct because bad manners seem to spread like a virus. Think about it. If someone treats you badly, you're just as likely to return the favor. It's human nature.

This e-mail suggests that we all celebrate National Etiquette Week by "encouraging the spread of courtesy, civility, good manners and kindness among young people, leaders, business people, and children." Stop spreading the bad manners virus. There's even a place in Charlotte that offers etiquette

classes and has offered its website to answer etiquette and manners questions.

Being nice to one another ought to be easy and a natural thing to do. But just in case you need some suggestions, the e-mail suggests you:

Spread a little e-kindness ... now this one should be easy to follow for all you computer nerds or people who use your computers a lot. Make up a nice little electronic note that is thoughtful and send it out to all your friends.

Spread working well with others...as they point out, kids in pre-school get graded on this so we adults ought to be able to master this as well.

Listen instead of speaking... we should and could all do better at this one. Look people in the eyes when they are telling you something and be genuinely interested.

Spread the touch of a handwritten note...I think this is the one skill that has really been lost in our society but it sure makes an impact when someone takes the time to pen a note and stick it in the mail. I know it really means a lot to me to receive a thoughtful note out of the blue.

So let's all take a little cue from the etiquette police and make it a point to celebrate Etiquette Week in May.
Thank you.